Business Continuity Plan

Document ID	SEC-013
Department	IT and Information Security
Document type	Plan
Owner	Chief Operating Officer
Version	4.2
Status	APPROVED
Effective / last reviewed	2025-06-14
Audience	All employees and contractors
Related documents	ENG-014, HR-003, SEC-010

Summary. The Northstar Systems Business Continuity Plan defines the Crisis Management Team led by the COO, disruption scenarios, Maximum Tolerable Downtime of 4 hours for customer platform operations, HQ unavailability response, communication tree, recovery priorities and annual exercises.

SYNTHETIC DOCUMENT - Northstar Systems is a fictional company. This document exists for development, testing and demonstration only and is not real legal, employment, security or compliance advice.

1. Purpose and Scope

This plan describes how Northstar Systems Private Limited keeps critical business activities running, or restores them within tolerable limits, when a serious disruption occurs. Disruptions include loss or damage of the Bengaluru HQ, loss of the Mumbai office, regional cloud failure, a major cyber attack, a pandemic or severe weather, a prolonged power or network outage, and the loss of a key supplier or a large number of staff. The plan protects people first, then customers, then revenue and reputation.

The plan applies to all employees and contractors and to every department: Human Resources, Engineering, IT/Security, Operations/Procurement with Finance, and Customer Success with Support. It covers the Bengaluru Whitefield HQ at Northstar Tower (about 340 staff), the Powai office in Mumbai (about 110 staff), remote staff across India (about 50), and the cloud environments of the Northstar Nexus Platform, Nexus Connect and Nexus Insight in the primary region Mumbai and the secondary (DR) region Hyderabad.

This plan sits above technical recovery detail. Backup, RPO and RTO standards are in ENG-014, remote working rules are in HR-003, and security incidents are managed through SEC-010. Where a legal or regulatory reference appears in this plan, it is illustrative and must be verified by Legal before external use.

2. Definitions

- **BCP**: Business Continuity Plan, this document.
- **BIA**: Business Impact Analysis, the annual study that identifies critical activities and how fast they must resume.
- **CMT**: Crisis Management Team, led by the COO.
- **MTD**: Maximum Tolerable Downtime, the longest an activity may be unavailable before the damage becomes unacceptable.

- **RPO**: Recovery Point Objective, the maximum acceptable data loss measured in time.
- **RTO**: Recovery Time Objective, the target time to restore a service.
- **Critical team**: a team whose work must continue during a disruption, as listed in the BIA.
- **DR failover**: switching Tier-1 and Tier-2 services from Mumbai to the secondary region Hyderabad.

3. Roles and Responsibilities

Role	Responsibility
COO	Chairs the CMT, declares a continuity event, owns this plan
CEO	Informed immediately; leads external stakeholder messages for major crises
CISO	Advises on cyber-related continuity, links to the Security Incident Response Team
CTO and VP Engineering	Lead technology recovery and DR failover decisions
VP Customer Success	Leads customer communication and service-level protection
Chief People Officer	Employee welfare, attendance, safety and family communication
CFO	Emergency funding, payroll continuity and supplier payments
General Counsel	Legal, contractual and regulatory obligations
Department heads	Maintain team recovery plans and call trees, lead their critical teams
Facilities	Building safety, evacuation, alternate site logistics
All staff	Keep contact details current in NorthPeople, follow instructions, join drills

4. Business Impact Analysis

The BIA is performed every year and updated after any major organisational or system change. It lists each business activity, its dependencies, the impact of downtime over time and the resulting priority. The BIA currently classifies the following activities as critical.

Activity	Owner	Target resumption
Customer platform operations (Nexus Platform, Nexus Connect)	CTO	Within 4 hours (MTD)
P1 and P2 customer support	VP Customer Success	Within 2 hours
Security monitoring in NorthWatch	CISO	Within 4 hours
Payroll processing in NorthPay	CFO	Before the last working day of the month
Customer billing and collections	CFO	Within 3 business days
Access management through NorthID	IT Operations	Within 2 hours
Hiring, onboarding and general HR services	Chief People Officer	Within 5 business days

The Maximum Tolerable Downtime for customer platform operations is 4 hours. Technical recovery targets by service tier are RPO 15 minutes and RTO 1 hour for Tier-1, RPO 4 hours and RTO 8 hours for Tier-2, and RPO 24 hours and RTO 72 hours for Tier-3, as set in ENG-014. Because the Tier-1 RTO of 1 hour is shorter than the 4-hour MTD, a single failover attempt that fails still leaves time for a second attempt before the MTD is reached.

5. Crisis Management Team

5.1 Composition and activation

The Crisis Management Team is led by the COO. Members are the CTO, CISO, CFO, VP Customer Success, Chief People Officer, General Counsel and the head of Facilities. Each member names a deputy in writing.

The CMT is activated when any member believes that a disruption could threaten life safety, stop a critical activity for more than half of its MTD, or damage the company's reputation. The COO declares a continuity event after a short assessment, normally within 30 minutes of the first report. Any CMT member may call a first meeting, and a decision to stand down is also made by the COO.

5.2 Operating rhythm

The CMT meets on a bridge call or in person at the first available location. In the first 24 hours it meets every 2 hours; afterwards daily or as the COO decides. A scribe records decisions, owners and times. Each critical team reports its status at each meeting using a short template: people safe, services up, customers affected, blockers and help needed.

5.3 Decision priorities

1 Safety of people.
2 Protection of customer data and customer-facing services.
3 Meeting legal, contractual and service-level obligations.
4 Payroll and payment continuity.
5 Reputation and communication.

6. Scenarios and Response

6.1 Bengaluru HQ unavailable

If the Bengaluru HQ is unavailable for any reason, such as fire, flooding, a power failure, a security threat or a government order, the following applies:

1 Facilities and the building security team evacuate and account for everyone at the emergency assembly points.
2 The COO declares a continuity event and informs all Bengaluru staff through the communication tree.
3 All Bengaluru staff work remotely within 4 hours of the declaration.
4 Critical teams operate from the Mumbai office at Powai, with seats allocated by the CMT in line with the critical activity list.
5 Staff use company laptops over NorthTunnel with MFA, as set out in SEC-009. The IT Service Desk (ext. 4000) supports users, and staff who cannot access laptops left at HQ receive loaners.
6 Customer Success posts a status update if services are affected, using Northstar Status and Enterprise and Premier email notices.
7 The CMT reviews the situation every 2 hours until stability returns, then decides how and when to resume HQ operations in phases.

Example: A severe flood makes Northstar Tower inaccessible at 07:30 on a Wednesday, an anchor day. The COO declares a continuity event at 08:00. By 12:00, which is within 4 hours, all Bengaluru employees are working from home. The Support Lead for Enterprise accounts and the

on-call engineers travel to Powai where 40 seats have been reserved for critical teams. P1 and P2 support continue without interruption. The CMT meets every 2 hours that day.

6.2 Mumbai office unavailable

Mumbai staff work remotely or from Bengaluru. Functions that depend on Mumbai-based teams, such as part of Finance and Customer Success, are covered by their documented alternates. Because the primary cloud region is also named Mumbai, a city-level event may affect both the office and the primary region; the CMT and Engineering must then consider DR failover to Hyderabad.

6.3 Cloud region failure

If the primary region Mumbai is unavailable, Engineering decides on DR failover to Hyderabad. The Incident Commander follows the engineering incident process in ENG-004 and the recovery runbooks. Tier-1 services must be restored within 1 hour. If failover is not complete after 2 hours, the CTO informs the CMT; if the outage approaches the 4-hour MTD, the COO informs the CEO and prepares customer communication from the communication library. Full DR failover drills are run twice a year, in April and October.

6.4 Cyber attack or ransomware

The Security Incident Response Team follows SEC-010. The CMT is activated for any Critical incident that threatens customer platform operations. Recovery uses clean backups copied to Hyderabad. Systems are reconnected only after the Incident Response Lead confirms that containment and eradication are complete.

6.5 Pandemic, severe weather or civil disruption

The Chief People Officer leads. Staff are asked to work remotely where possible, and travel restrictions apply as announced. Critical teams keep at least two trained people for each critical activity. Office re-entry may be phased, and hybrid anchor days may be suspended by the COO for the period of the event.

6.6 Loss of a key supplier

Procurement and the business owner identify alternate suppliers for Critical vendors, as assessed under SEC-011. For a hosting, network or payroll provider failure, the CMT approves emergency use of a pre-qualified alternate and an emergency purchase, subject to Delegation of Authority limits and, for amounts above INR 2,00,000, CFO approval.

6.7 Loss of key people

Each critical team keeps a succession list and documented procedures so that two trained deputies exist for every critical role. Cross-training takes place at least once a year.

7. Communication

7.1 Communication tree

The communication tree runs from the COO to CMT members, then to department heads, then to team leads and individual employees. Messages are sent by phone call and SMS, and the emergency notification tool is used for mass notification with acknowledgement tracking. Each recipient must acknowledge within 30 minutes. Where a person does not respond, the team lead calls their emergency contact stored in NorthPeople. Contact details must be reviewed by every

employee at least twice a year, and a reminder is sent in April and October.

7.2 Employees

The Chief People Officer sends updates to employees at least every 4 hours during the first day of an event and daily afterwards. Messages state whether to come to the office, where to work, how to get help and who to call. Staff must not post about the event on social media on behalf of the company.

7.3 Customers and external parties

Customer Success sends the first notification within 30 minutes of declaring a SEV1 or SEV2 that affects customers, through Northstar Status and by email to Enterprise and Premier contacts. Messages are plain and empathetic and do not promise dates that Engineering has not confirmed. Media and regulator statements are issued only by the CEO or by Legal.

8. Recovery Strategies

Resource	Strategy
People	Remote work, Mumbai alternate site, cross-trained deputies
Premises	Alternate site at Powai, temporary co-working agreements through Facilities
Technology	Secondary region Hyderabad, daily full backups plus 15-minute log shipping for Tier-1 databases
Data	Backups encrypted and copied to Hyderabad, quarterly restore tests
Suppliers	Alternate vendors for Critical suppliers
Information	Critical contact lists, runbooks and this plan stored in more than one location outside the affected site

Laptops are the default work equipment, so a loss of premises should not stop work. Staff must keep laptops charged and take them home on days when severe weather is forecast.

9. Testing and Maintenance

- The BIA is updated annually.
- A BCP exercise is held once a year; scenarios rotate among HQ loss, regional cloud failure, ransomware and loss of a key supplier.
- DR failover drills run twice a year, in April and October, and results go to the CMT.
- Communication-tree tests are run every quarter. An acknowledgement rate below 90 percent within 30 minutes triggers an action plan.
- Backup restore tests are run quarterly by Engineering.
- The plan is reviewed at least once a year, and also after every real activation, significant organisational change or exercise with major findings.
- Findings from drills and real events are tracked in NorthDesk with owners and due dates; high findings are remediated within 60 days.

Example: In the October DR drill, Engineering fails over three Tier-1 services to Hyderabad. Two come up within 40 minutes, and one takes 95 minutes because a firewall rule was missing. The CMT records a finding, the owner closes it within 30 days, and the next drill confirms the fix.

10. Payroll and Finance Continuity

Payroll is credited on the last working day of each month. If NorthPay or the banking channel is disrupted, Finance uses the documented manual payment procedure with CFO approval, so employees are paid on time or within 2 working days at most. The CFO may approve emergency spending above normal limits for the event, and the CFO and CEO jointly approve amounts above INR 10,00,000, as set by the Delegation of Authority. Emergency purchases still need a PO, raised after the event if necessary, and must be recorded in NorthBuy.

11. Employee Guidance During an Event

Employees should follow these steps when a continuity event is declared:

1 Make sure you and your family are safe before anything else, and tell your manager if you cannot work.
2 Acknowledge the notification from the emergency notification tool within 30 minutes.
3 Work from home unless told to report to the Powai alternate site; take your company laptop and charger, and connect through NorthTunnel with MFA.
4 Raise access or equipment problems with the IT Service Desk at ext. 4000, and report any security concern to the Security Desk at ext. 5555.
5 Do not speak to the media, customers or on social media about the event unless you are a designated spokesperson; refer enquiries to your manager or the Communications Lead.
6 Record attendance in NorthPeople as normal; the Chief People Officer will confirm if special attendance rules apply.
7 Return to the office only when the all-clear message is sent by the COO or the Chief People Officer.

Managers must confirm the safety of every team member and report headcount, missing contacts and critical-activity status to their department head within 2 hours of the declaration.

12. Exceptions and Escalation

The COO may adapt this plan during an event, recording the reason. A team that cannot meet its recovery target must tell the CMT at once. Disputes between functions are decided by the COO. A department that cannot maintain its recovery plan or call tree may request a time-limited exception from the COO, which must not exceed 90 days. Questions about the plan go to the Office of the COO.

13. Frequently Asked Questions

- **Who leads in a crisis?** The COO leads the Crisis Management Team.
- **What if HQ is unavailable?** All Bengaluru staff work remotely within 4 hours, and critical teams operate from Mumbai.
- **What is the longest the customer platform may be down?** The Maximum Tolerable Downtime for customer platform operations is 4 hours.
- **How often is the plan exercised?** A BCP exercise is held annually, and DR failover drills run in April and October.
- **How will I be told what to do?** Through the communication tree by phone and SMS, and the emergency notification tool. Keep your contact details current in NorthPeople.

14. Related Documents

See ENG-014 for backup and disaster recovery, HR-003 for remote work, SEC-010 for security incident response, SEC-009 for remote access and SEC-011 for supplier risk.

15. Revision History

Version	Date	Change
4.0	2024-06-10	Added regional cloud failure scenario and communication-tree testing
4.2	2025-06-14	Updated HQ unavailability steps and BIA activity table